🗓️ Timeline & Cartoons: BASIC Cartoon Handout

US History · Unit 1 · Level 2 (modified) · how to read a political cartoon

Name: _____

Use BASIC on every political cartoon this year.

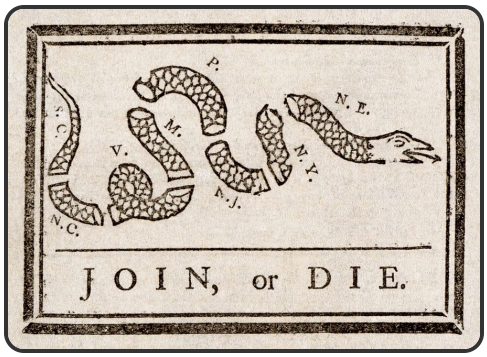
What is BASIC?

Letter	Step	Ask yourself
B	**Background**	What was going on at the time? Who are the people?
A	**Argument**	What does the cartoonist want me to believe?
S	**Symbols**	What do the pictures stand for? (Uncle Sam = USA, dove = peace)
I	**Indicators**	Read ALL the words: title, labels, caption.
C	**Caricature**	What is exaggerated (drawn too big or small) to make a point?

1. Political cartoons try to _____ you. They give an opinion.
2. They are on the _____ (opinion) page, not with the comics.
3. Old cartoons are hard because we may not know the _____ of the time.

Word bank: **background** **editorial** **persuade**

Practice: Join, or Die (1754)



"Join, or Die." Benjamin Franklin, 1754 (public domain)

4. B: Background. In 1754 the colonies were about to fight…

A. France (the French and Indian War) | B. Mexico | C. England

5. S: What does each piece of the snake stand for?

A. a soldier | B. a colony | C. a state today

6. I: The letters N.E., N.Y., P., V. and others are…

A. the artist's name | B. labels for the colonies | C. a date

7. A: What is Franklin's argument?

A. The colonies must unite or they will be destroyed	B. Snakes are dangerous	C. The colonies should split apart

8. List 2 symbols most Americans know today and what they mean.